

probably don't know this stuff. So, they will revert the bowler to the same mixed action or flawed posture. Without technical and biomechanical correction, the injury risk remains the same," Pont says.

Aaron was 22 when he had his eighth stress fracture. And it was during the rehab after his surgery that he realised his old action needed to be tweaked. "I stopped getting stress fractures once I made the right biomechanical adjustment," he says. "That was my last fracture," he adds.

Fast and furious

A 21-year-old, Mayank Yadav (**pic, right**), took everyone by surprise by consistently clocking speeds over 150 km/h when he made his IPL debut in 2024. His fastest delivery saw the speedometer touch 156.7 km/h – the second-fastest for an Indian after Umran Malik's 157 km/h thunderbolt in the 2022 season. Umran had also made his IPL debut at 21 years in 2021 for Sunrisers Hyderabad.

While the explosive pace drew immediate attention, it also came with physical consequences.

Mayank managed just four games for Lucknow Super Giants before a back injury ruled him out. He returned in October to make his T20I debut for India. But, much to his misery, he took another trip to BCCI's Centre of Excellence (formerly NCA) owing to the same injury.

"Mayank and Umran Malik have fast, exciting actions but with high spinal loads and injury risk," Pont notes. "Modifying them slightly to reduce spinal twisting or increase load sharing can reduce the injury risk," he adds.

Mayank's highly anticipated return in IPL 2025 was delayed due to his extended rehab programme. He eventually arrived, played two games, before his injury reappeared, ruling him out of the season. Umran, too, was sidelined due to a hip injury.

"Bone density drops significantly

in and around the spinal segment after a stress fracture," John Gloster, Rajasthan Royals' head physiotherapist, says. "B bowlers are usually sidelined for 4–6 months, but bone density remains low for 6–10 months after recovery, heightening re-injury risk."

Gloster believes there's excitement when a 150 km/h fast bowler comes along, but managing them requires restraint. "Overexcitement can lead to overbowling."

India hardly produces speedsters like Aaron, Mayank, and Umran, who can touch 150 km/h consistently. So, when they come along, there is a



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tendency to rush them into the system. "There's a scarcity mindset. As soon as someone clicks 150 km/h, particularly in India, they are treated as a rare asset. Selectors and franchises feel they must get as much as they can, and quickly, before they get injured or drop form," Pont opines.

"In the IPL, there's a lot of franchise pressure. The teams see raw pacers as match-winning weapons. Young pacers can suddenly go from bowling 10 to 12 hours a week at full speed to three days with little build-up. There's pressure on these guys to keep bowling faster. There's a lack of patience and long-term planning," he adds.

Leipus worked with the Indian team from 1999 to 2004 and says the landscape has changed dramatically since. "Workload tracking is better understood and more sophisticated, and treatment modalities and interventions have evolved so we can mitigate injury recurrence," notes Leipus, who has also worked with Kolkata Knight Riders in the past.

The IPL typically spans from late March, concluding the international calendar, to late May, which marks the onset of the new cricket season.

Several international players arrive after finishing a series and leave the tournament to join the national team, hardly getting a chance to rest. Most often than not, there is a change in format almost immediately.

"Switching formats on short notice is incredibly demanding, especially for fast bowlers,"

Leipus says. "Test match bowling is about volume, rhythm, and control. T20 demands are almost the opposite – explosive spells, variation, and max effort. That quick pivot can be a challenge to the body if not managed carefully. T20s themselves aren't the problem – it's